One of the major success stories was the signing of the contract with IdeaForge for the 'Switch' unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) in January 2021 for a cost of Rs 140 crore, barely six months after the powers had been delegated, after following all norms and financial formalities. In fact, this was one aspect that we, the VCOAS and I, were very particular about, namely that there should not be any deviation from the established procedure that might lead to finger-pointing later on, about misuse of these delegated powers. The first of these UAVs started getting delivered well within the contracted period and are in service in Eastern Ladakh. Another positive fallout was that IdeaForge, a start-up, had won this contract while competing against well-established players such as the Tata Group, Dynamatic Technologies Ltd, and even Israel's Elbit Systems. This gave a big boost to the Atmanirbhar Bharat and Make in India campaigns, besides giving confidence to the MSMEs. During this phase of the delegation of Emergency Powers (EP-1 to EP-3), we were able to place orders/sign as many as sixty-eight different contracts for over Rs 6600 crore, of which almost 70 per cent were with Indian firms.

More than anything else, this showed that the entire acquisition process can be shortened and made more efficient if the focus is on outcomes—the product, rather than the process. The delegation of the powers to the Service HQ, the users, automatically resulted in the change in focus. Greater delegation is needed, particularly if the orders are going to Indian firms and entities, as it is our own local economy that will get a boost. This should be the norm rather than an 'Emergency' delegation. Control can be exercised through the budget allocation, but once allocated, there should be no need for any more intra-ministerial oversight, as the CAG[20] would in any case carry out the oversight function in due course.

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